

PATHWAYS · EDUCATOR GUIDE

Producing a CV

Activity · 45-60 min facilitated, plus independent drafting

Pairs for drafting, whole group for reflection · 10-30 learners

Purpose

Learners draft a first CV that showcases their strengths and experience, then get feedback on it, so they have a document ready to adapt for real pathway applications. A CV is often the first thing a pathway provider sees, so this activity is about turning a learner's real experience into a document that does it justice.

The one thing to get right

Learners routinely undersell themselves, leaving off responsibilities, volunteering, languages and informal work because they assume these do not count. Your main job is to help them see the value in what they have already done. Feedback on the actual draft matters more than any amount of general advice, so protect time for it.

Materials and preparation

- The CV-building resource (video and slides) or your own worked walkthrough if you prefer to lead it live.
- A simple CV template and one strong example CV for learners to model, adapted to your context.
- The Pathways Journal for each learner to store and revisit their CV.
- Note on local conventions [to verify]: CV norms differ by country and sector (length, whether to include a photo, date of birth or marital status). Check what is expected for the pathways your learners are applying to, and tell them plainly, since a borrowed template can carry the wrong norms.

Step by step

Step 1. Set what a strong CV is for 5-10 min

Start with the purpose: a CV is a short, honest advert for what a learner can offer, aimed at a specific opportunity. Show one strong example and draw out what makes it work: clear structure, concrete achievements, no wasted words. Flag early that conventions vary by place, so the example is a model of quality, not a fixed template.

KEY PROMPTS

- Who reads a CV, and how long do you think they spend on it at first?
- What makes this example easy or hard to read quickly?
- What is the difference between listing a duty and showing an achievement?

WATCH-OUTS

- Learners treat the example as a rigid form to copy exactly; stress that structure and clarity transfer but details like length and personal information depend on where they are applying.

Learners draft a CV that fits their own experience, working in pairs so each can prompt the other. The pair's job is to pull out things the writer is undervaluing: responsibilities at home, volunteering, languages spoken, informal or family work, skills built in the Amala programme. Ask learners to save the draft into their Pathways Journal.

KEY PROMPTS

- What have you done, paid or unpaid, where people relied on you?
- What can you do that not everyone can, including languages and practical skills?
- Your partner just told me something impressive about you: is it on your CV yet?

WATCH-OUTS

- Learners leave gaps blank and feel they have no experience; help them count unpaid, informal and community experience, and frame skills gained through the programme itself as legitimate CV content.

Step 3. Give and get feedback on the draft 15-20 min

Move learners into a feedback round, ideally one-to-one with you or a mentor, or structured peer feedback if not. Feedback should be specific and about the document: which entry is unclear, where an achievement is hiding inside a duty, what to cut. Keep it kind and concrete, and have learners make at least one improvement there and then.

KEY PROMPTS

- Which line here would make a reader want to know more, and which would they skim past?
- Where have you described a task when you could describe a result?
- What is one change you will make right now based on this feedback?

WATCH-OUTS

- Feedback stays vague and nothing changes; model one specific, usable comment yourself first, and ask each learner to name the single change they are making.

Step 4. Reflect on how the CV serves your pathways 5 min

Close by connecting the document back to the point of the course. Ask learners how they found the process, how happy they are with the draft, and how a strong CV helps them reach the pathways they are aiming for. Capture the reflection in the journal so the CV is understood as a tool they will reuse and adapt.

KEY PROMPTS

- How happy are you with your CV, and what would make it stronger?
- What did you learn about showcasing your strengths?
- Which upcoming opportunity will you adapt this CV for first?

WATCH-OUTS

- Learners file the CV away as finished; remind them a CV is tailored per application and should be revisited whenever they apply somewhere new.

Running this in different settings

Group (designed for this)

Learners draft in pairs so they can prompt each other for strengths and experiences they would undersell alone, then reflect as a group. Build in a separate slot for one-to-one CV feedback.

One-to-one mentoring

A strong fit for the feedback stage. A mentor works through a learner's draft line by line. Have the learner do the first draft before the session so the time is spent improving a real document.

Independent

Workable for the drafting, weaker for the feedback that makes a CV good. Give a checklist of what a strong CV entry looks like and arrange at least one round of feedback before the CV is treated as finished.

Competencies learners develop and demonstrate

FSL3 - Engage in continuous learning

Building a CV is learners actively developing a transferable skill relevant across every pathway; the saved and revisited document evidences ongoing skill-building.

FLC3 - Influential communication

A CV is persuasive communication aimed at a specific audience, and drafting one teaches learners to present themselves so a reader is convinced.

ASL1 - Using feedback

The feedback round, where learners take specific comment on their draft and make a change on the spot, is direct practice in assessing and using feedback to improve an outcome.

Closing

Ask a couple of learners to name one strength they had undervalued until a partner or the group pointed it out. Remind everyone the CV lives in their Pathways Journal and is meant to grow: every new experience, and every application, is a reason to come back and sharpen it.